NORTHSTAR DIGITAL SERVICES LTD.

People Operations · Finance · Information Security

Leave and Absence Standard

Detailed procedures for annual leave, sickness, family and other leave

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1.1	August 2026	Consultation draft; not issued.
1.2	1 October 2026	Approved and issued. Supersedes Leave Policy NDS-HR-LV-006 v1.0.

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1 Purpose, scope and status

1.1 Purpose

This Leave and Absence Standard (NDS-HR-LAS-002, version 1.2) is the authoritative, detailed procedure for annual leave, sickness absence, family-related leave and other leave at Northstar Digital Services Ltd. It expands sections 6 to 9 of the Employee Handbook NDS-HR-HB-001 v2.0. The values in this Standard and the handbook are the same; where this Standard gives more detail, this Standard prevails (handbook section 1.5).

1.2 Scope

This Standard applies to all employees (permanent, part-time, fixed-term, apprentices and interns) employed under contracts governed by the law of England and Wales. It does not apply to contractors or agency workers. Employees based in Scotland or Northern Ireland are covered subject to the local review described in handbook section 1.8.

1.3 Effective date and superseded document

This Standard is effective from **1 October 2026**. It supersedes the Leave Policy NDS-HR-LV-006 v1.0, which applied from 1 January 2025 to 30 September 2026. The archived Leave Policy must not be used for current decisions; transitional rules are in section 3.9.

1.4 General conventions used in this Standard

Table 1.4 — Calculation conventions

Convention	Rule
Leave year	1 January to 31 December.
Working day	Monday to Friday excluding England and Wales bank holidays, unless the employee's contract specifies another pattern.
Full-time day	7.5 hours. A full-time half day is 3.75 hours.
Counting notice	Working days between the submission date and the first day of leave, counting neither date.
Calendar days for pro-rating	Count inclusive of the start date and the leaving date; 365 days in a leave year (366 in a leap year).
Rounding — days	Round pro-rated entitlements up to the nearest 0.5 day.
Rounding — hours	Round pro-rated entitlements up to the nearest 0.25 hour.
Rounding — money	Round to the nearest penny.
Daily rate	Annual basic salary / 260.
Hourly rate	Annual basic salary / (52 x contracted weekly hours).
Statutory floor	No calculation may result in less than the statutory minimum of 5.6 weeks' paid holiday.

2 Roles and records

Table 2.1 — Roles in leave and absence administration

Role	Responsibilities
Employee	Requests leave in PeopleHub with the required notice; reports absence by telephone or Teams call; provides evidence; keeps their manager updated.
Line manager	Responds to leave requests within 5 working days; maintains team coverage; records absences; holds return-to-work conversations; refers to People Operations where needed.
Head of Department	Approves leave in critical delivery periods, leave over 10 consecutive working days, negative balances and short-notice exceptions; reviews declined requests.
People Operations	Administers family leave and statutory pay; maintains PeopleHub records; advises on triggers, Occupational Health and adjustments.
Payroll	Calculates statutory and company pay, final holiday payments and deductions.

All leave and absence is recorded in PeopleHub. Absence records are retained for 3 years after the end of the leave year in which the absence occurred; family leave pay records are retained with payroll records for 6 years from the end of the tax year (handbook Table 18.4).

3 Annual leave

3.1 Entitlement

Table 3.1 — Annual leave entitlement (full-time, 37.5 hours over 5 days)

Continuous service completed	Annual leave days	Bank holidays	Total days	Total hours
Less than 3 years	27	8	35	262.5
3 years or more, less than 5 years	28	8	36	270.0
5 years or more	29	8	37	277.5

Service increments apply from the first 1 January that falls after the employee completes the required service.

> **Service increment timing**
>
> - Start date 15 March 2024: 3 years completed on 14 March 2027. The first 1 January after that is 1 January 2028, so the employee receives 28 days from the 2028 leave year. In 2027 the entitlement remains 27 days.
> - Start date 1 January 2024: 3 years completed at the end of 31 December 2026. The first 1 January after that is 1 January 2027, so the employee receives 28 days in the 2027 leave year.

3.2 Accrual and booking

Leave accrues at one-twelfth of the annual entitlement per complete calendar month. After probation, the full annual entitlement may be booked in advance. During probation, the bookable amount is accrued leave (rounded up to the nearest 0.5 day) plus up to 2 additional days with line manager approval.

> **Booking during probation**
>
> A full-time employee starts on 1 March 2027. On 1 June 2027 they have 3 complete months of service. Accrued leave = 27 x 3 / 12 = 6.75 days, rounded up to 7.0 days. With line manager approval they may book up to 7.0 + 2 = **9.0 days** for leave starting on or around that date. Any period of more than 5 consecutive working days also needs Head of Department approval.

3.3 Part-time employees

Part-time allowances are calculated in hours: total allowance = full-time total hours for the employee's service band x (contracted weekly hours / 37.5), rounded up to the nearest 0.25 hour. Bank holidays falling on normal working days are deducted at the hours normally worked that day; the remainder is bookable annual leave. The part-time carryover limit is 37.5 hours x FTE, and the part-time hourly-leave limit is 37.5 hours x FTE.

3.4 Changes to working hours during the leave year

Divide the leave year at the date of change, calculate each period unrounded as (annual allowance for that pattern) x (calendar days in period / days in year), add the periods, round the total up to the nearest 0.25 hour, then deduct bank holidays on working days for each period.

Worked example 3.4A — full-time to part-time

An employee with less than 3 years' service works full-time (37.5 hours, Monday to Friday) from 1 January to 30 June 2027 (181 days) and 22.5 hours (Monday to Wednesday, 7.5 hours per day) from 1 July to 31 December 2027 (184 days).

- Period 1: 262.5 x 181 / 365 = 130.171 hours
- Period 2: 157.5 x 184 / 365 = 79.397 hours
- Total: 209.568 hours, rounded up to **209.75 hours**
- Bank holidays on working days, period 1 (1 Jan, 26 Mar, 29 Mar, 3 May, 31 May): 5 x 7.5 = 37.5 hours
- Bank holidays on working days, period 2 (30 Aug, 27 Dec, 28 Dec): 3 x 7.5 = 22.5 hours
- Bookable annual leave for 2027: 209.75 − 37.5 − 22.5 = **149.75 hours**
- If the employee took 60 hours of annual leave in period 1, the remaining balance from 1 July is 149.75 − 60 = **89.75 hours**, of which 7.5 hours must be reserved for the shutdown day that falls on a working day (Wednesday 29 December 2027).

Worked example 3.4B — part-time to full-time

An employee with less than 3 years' service works 22.5 hours (Monday to Wednesday) from 1 January to 31 March 2027 (90 days), then full-time from 1 April to 31 December 2027 (275 days).

- Period 1: 157.5 x 90 / 365 = 38.836 hours
- Period 2: 262.5 x 275 / 365 = 197.774 hours
- Total: 236.610 hours, rounded up to **236.75 hours**
- Bank holidays on working days: period 1 (29 Mar) 7.5 hours; period 2 (3 May, 31 May, 30 Aug, 27 Dec, 28 Dec) 37.5 hours; total 45 hours
- Bookable annual leave for 2027: 236.75 − 45 = **191.75 hours**

3.5 Joiners and leavers

Pro-rated entitlement = annual entitlement x (calendar days employed in the leave year / days in the leave year), rounded up (0.5 day for day-based, 0.25 hour for hours-based).

Worked examples 3.5 — joiners

- **Full-time joiner, 1 March 2027:** 27 x 306 / 365 = 22.636, rounded up to **23.0 days**, plus 7 bank holidays from 26 March 2027.
- **Full-time joiner, 16 September 2027:** calendar days 16 September to 31 December = 107. 27 x 107 / 365 = 7.915, rounded up to **8.0 days**, plus the 27 and 28 December bank holidays. Three of these days must be reserved for the 2027 shutdown (29 to 31 December).
- **Part-time joiner, 1 July 2027, 22.5 hours Monday to Wednesday:** 157.5 x 184 / 365 = 79.397, rounded up to **79.5 hours**. Bank holidays on working days (30 Aug, 27 Dec, 28 Dec) = 22.5 hours. Bookable annual leave = **57.0 hours**.

Worked examples 3.5 — leavers

- **Full-time leaver, 30 June 2027, salary £45,500:** 27 x 181 / 365 = 13.389, rounded up to 13.5 days. Taken 10 days: balance 3.5 days x £175.00 = **£612.50** paid. Taken 15 days: balance −1.5 days x £175.00 = **£262.50** deducted where the contract permits.
- **Part-time leaver, 31 March 2027, 30 hours Monday to Thursday, salary £32,000:** 210 x 90 / 365 = 51.781, rounded up to 52.0 hours. Bank holiday on a working day (29 March) = 7.5 hours, leaving 44.5 bookable hours. Taken 30 hours: balance 14.5 hours. Hourly rate = £32,000 / (52 x 30) = £20.5128. Payment = 14.5 x £20.5128 = **£297.44**.

3.6 Requesting and approving leave

Table 3.6 — Minimum notice and approvals (requests submitted on or after 1 October 2026)

Length of leave	Minimum notice (working days)	Approval
Up to 1 working day, including hourly and half-day leave	2	Line manager
More than 1 and up to 5 working days	10	Line manager
More than 5 and up to 10 working days	20	Line manager
More than 10 and up to 15 consecutive working days	40	Line manager and Head of Department
More than 15 consecutive working days	40	Line manager, Head of Department and Director

Procedure:

1. The employee submits the request in PeopleHub, adding a note if the dates are linked to religious observance, caring responsibilities or an event that cannot be moved.
2. The line manager checks the balance, team coverage (no more than 30% of the team, rounded down, minimum one person) and any critical delivery period, and decides within **5 working days**.
3. If there is no decision after 5 working days, PeopleHub escalates the request to the Head of Department. Silence is never approval.
4. If declined, the manager records the business reason. The employee may request a Head of Department review within 5 working days; the Head of Department responds within 5 working days.

Worked example 3.6 — counting notice

An employee submits a request on Monday 1 February 2027 for 3 days starting Monday 15 February 2027. The working days between the two dates are 2, 3, 4, 5, 8, 9, 10, 11 and 12 February = **9 working days**. The minimum is 10, so the request is short notice and may be approved only at the manager's discretion. If the leave started on Tuesday 16 February 2027, there would be 10 working days of notice and the notice requirement would be met.

3.7 Critical delivery periods and team coverage

A Head of Department may publish a critical delivery period in PeopleHub at least 6 weeks before it starts, lasting no more than 15 working days, with no more than 2 per team per leave year. During that period, annual leave also requires Head of Department approval and is approved only exceptionally (for example, a family wedding booked before the period was published, or compassionate reasons). Leave approved before publication stays approved unless cancelled under handbook section 6.13, with re-credit of the leave and reimbursement of evidenced non-refundable costs.

3.8 Carryover

Table 3.8 — Carryover rules

Type	Maximum	Deadline to use	Approval
Standard	5 days (37.5 hours x FTE)	31 March of the next leave year	None
Sickness prevented leave	Up to 4 weeks (20 days x FTE), in addition to standard	18 months after the end of the leave year in which it accrued	Automatic, with absence records
Family-related leave prevented leave	All untaken leave for the year	12 months after the return-to-work date	Automatic
Exceptional business reasons	A further 5 days (10 days total)	30 June of the next leave year	Director of People Operations; request by 30 November

Worked examples 3.8 — carryover

- **Standard:** a full-time employee has 27 days in 2027 and has taken 20 days by 31 December 2027 (including the 3 shutdown days). Unused = 7 days. They carry over **5 days**, which must be taken by 31 March 2028, and **2 days are lost** unless an exception is approved.
- **Part-time limit:** an employee at 0.6 FTE may carry over up to 37.5 x 0.6 = **22.5 hours**.
- **Sickness:** a full-time employee was on sick leave from September to December 2027 and has 15 unused days. They carry over 5 standard days (use by 31 March 2028) and the remaining 10 days under the sickness rule (use by 30 June 2029, 18 months after 31 December 2027).
- **2026 into 2027:** a full-time employee with a 2026 transitional entitlement of 25.5 days took 22 days in 2026. Unused = 3.5 days, which is within the 5-day limit, so all **3.5 days** carry over and must be taken by 31 March 2027.

3.9 Transitional arrangements (2026 leave year)

Table 3.9 — Transitional rules from the archived Leave Policy NDS-HR-LV-006 v1.0

Topic	Archived policy v1.0 (1 Jan 2025 – 30 Sep 2026)	This Standard v1.2 (from 1 Oct 2026)
Full-time annual leave	25 days plus bank holidays	27 days plus bank holidays (2027 onwards)
2026 full-time entitlement	—	25.5 days (less than 5 years' service); 26.5 days (5 years or more)
Service increments	+1 day after 5 years	+1 day after 3 years; +2 days after 5 years (from 1 January 2027)
Notice for up to 5 days	5 working days	2 working days (up to 1 day); 10 working days (more than 1 and up to 5 days)
Notice for more than 5 days	20 working days	20 working days (up to 10 days); 40 working days (more than 10 days)
Manager response time	10 working days	5 working days
Carryover	3 days, use by 28 February	5 days, use by 31 March
Hourly leave	Not available	Available from 1 October 2026
Negative balance	Not permitted	Up to 3 days with Head of Department approval
Sickness reporting deadline	10:00	09:30

Which rules apply to a request? The notice and approval rules are those in force on the date the request was submitted. Entitlement and carryover are determined by the leave year.

Worked examples 3.9 — transition

- **Request submitted Monday 28 September 2026** for 3 days starting Tuesday 6 October 2026. Working days between: 29 and 30 September, 1, 2 and 5 October = 5. The request was submitted before 1 October 2026, so the archived rule (5 working days for up to 5 days) applies and the notice requirement is **met**.
- **Request submitted Thursday 1 October 2026** for 3 days starting Monday 12 October 2026. Working days between: 2, 5, 6, 7, 8 and 9 October = 6. The current rule (10 working days) applies, so this is **short notice**.
- **Part-time 2026 entitlement (3 days per week, 0.6 FTE, less than 5 years' service):** archived allowance 15 days (112.5 hours) plus bank holidays on working days, plus a transitional uplift of 3.75 x 0.6 = **2.25 hours**, giving 114.75 hours of annual leave.

3.10 Company shutdown

Three days are reserved each year for the shutdown between Christmas and New Year: 29 to 31 December 2026 and 29 to 31 December 2027. Part-time employees reserve only the shutdown days that fall on their working days. Employees rostered to work during the shutdown take the equivalent leave at another time agreed with their manager.

3.11 Sickness during annual leave

Report sickness by 09:30 on the first day of sickness under section 4.1, even while on leave. Provide self-certification (1 to 7 calendar days) or a fit note (more than 7 calendar days). The manager reclassifies the days in PeopleHub and the leave is re-credited. Sickness reported only after returning from leave is not normally reclassified.

3.12 Leave during notice periods and on termination

Employees under notice may request leave normally. Northstar may require accrued leave to be taken during notice by giving notice of at least twice the length of the leave required. Leave booked after the leaving date is cancelled. The final balance is the pro-rated entitlement to the leaving date, plus valid carryover, minus leave taken or booked; positive balances are paid and negative balances deducted where the contract permits (section 3.5 examples).

4 Sickness absence

4.1 Reporting

Table 4.1 — Sickness reporting requirements

Requirement	Rule
Deadline	By **09:30** on the first day of absence; shift and on-call workers at least 1 hour before the shift or rota period.
Channel	Telephone or Teams call to the line manager (Head of Department or team lead if unavailable). Text, chat or email alone is not sufficient unless the employee is physically unable to speak.
Record	Absence recorded in PeopleHub the same day by the employee or manager.
Updates	On the third working day, then at least weekly.
Return	Self-certification on return; return-to-work conversation within 2 working days.

4.2 Evidence

Self-certification covers up to 7 calendar days (including non-working days). A fit note is required for absences of more than 7 calendar days, submitted within 3 working days of issue. Northstar may require fit notes for all absences once an employee reaches Stage 1 of the attendance process and will reimburse any charge.

4.3 Statutory Sick Pay

From 6 April 2026, SSP is payable from the first qualifying day of sickness at the lower of £123.25 per week or 80% of normal weekly earnings, for up to 28 weeks. Northstar's qualifying days are contracted working days. The daily SSP rate is the weekly rate divided by the number of qualifying days in the week.

4.4 Company sick pay

Table 4.4 — Company sick pay (inclusive of SSP) in any rolling 12 months

Continuous service on first day of absence	Full pay	Half pay
During probation	SSP only	SSP only
Probation completed, less than 2 years	4 weeks	4 weeks
2 years or more, less than 5 years	8 weeks	8 weeks
5 years or more	13 weeks	13 weeks

Worked examples 4.4 — sick pay

- **Probation:** a full-time employee in probation (normal weekly earnings above £154.07, so the £123.25 rate applies) is absent for 4 working days. Daily SSP = £123.25 / 5 = £24.65. SSP payable = 4 x £24.65 = **£98.60**. No company sick pay is due.
- **3 years' service:** an employee who has already received 5 weeks of full company sick pay in the previous 12 months is absent for 6 weeks. Remaining full-pay weeks = 8 − 5 = 3. They receive 3 weeks at full pay and 3 weeks at half pay.
- **6 years' service, salary £52,000, no previous sick pay in 12 months, absent 15 weeks:** 13 weeks at full pay (£1,000 per week) and 2 weeks at half pay (£500 per week, which is more than SSP). Pay for weeks 14 and 15 = 2 x £500 = **£1,000**.

Company sick pay may be withheld for days where the reporting or evidence rules were not followed without good reason; SSP remains payable where the statutory conditions are met.

4.5 Attendance review triggers

A Stage 0 supportive review is triggered by 3 or more separate absences, or 8 or more working days of absence, in a rolling 12 months. Later stages follow handbook Table 7.6. Pregnancy-related absence is excluded from triggers. Disability-related absence is recorded separately and triggers may be adjusted as a reasonable adjustment.

4.6 Long-term absence and Occupational Health

Absence of 4 consecutive weeks or more is long-term; an Occupational Health referral is normally made at that point. Welfare contact is agreed with the employee and takes place at least every 2 weeks.

4.7 Return to work and phased return

Return-to-work conversations take place within 2 working days of return. Phased returns of up to 4 weeks are on full pay; longer phased returns need Head of Department approval, with the balance of hours covered by annual leave or remaining company sick pay.

5 Family-related leave procedures

Each card below sets out the procedure. Statutory rates are for 2026/27. "AWE" means average weekly earnings.

Card 5.1 — Maternity leave

Element	Detail
Purpose and scope	Leave before and after childbirth for pregnant employees.
Eligibility	All employees from day one. SMP: 26 weeks' continuous service into the 15th week before the EWC and AWE of at least £129. Enhanced pay: SMP-eligible and 26 weeks' service at the end of the 15th week before the EWC.
Entitlement	Up to 52 weeks (26 ordinary + 26 additional). Compulsory 2 weeks after birth. Earliest start 11 weeks before the EWC.
Pay	Weeks 1–16 full basic pay (inclusive of SMP) if enhanced-eligible; weeks 17–39 SMP; weeks 40–52 unpaid. SMP: 90% of AWE for 6 weeks, then £194.32 or 90% of AWE if lower, for 33 weeks.
Notice	By the end of the 15th week before the EWC (pregnancy, EWC, start date). 28 days' notice of SMP start. 8 weeks' notice to change the return date.
Steps	Submit "Maternity leave" form in PeopleHub; upload MATB1 within 21 days of SMP start; agree KIT day arrangements; complete pregnancy risk assessment with manager.
Documents	MATB1 or doctor/midwife letter.
Approver	Not subject to approval; People Operations confirms dates.
Response deadline	People Operations confirms the expected return date in writing within 28 days of notification.
Escalation	Director of People Operations.
Records	PeopleHub family-leave record; payroll SMP records.
Special circumstances	Pregnancy-related absence in the 4 weeks before the EWC may trigger leave automatically; enhanced pay repayable if the employee does not return for 6 months (exceptions in handbook section 8.1).

Worked example 5.1 — enhanced maternity pay eligibility

An employee's EWC begins on Sunday 6 June 2027. The 15th week before the EWC (the qualifying week) begins on Sunday 21 February 2027 and ends on Saturday 27 February 2027. An employee who started on 1 March 2026 has well over 26 weeks' continuous service by the end of the qualifying week, so she qualifies for SMP and Northstar enhanced pay, provided her AWE is at least £129. An employee who started on 1 November 2026 has only about 17 weeks' service by the end of the qualifying week. She is entitled to 52 weeks' maternity leave but not to SMP or enhanced pay; she may be able to claim Maternity Allowance. People Operations confirms exact service calculations in borderline cases.

Card 5.2 — Paternity leave

Element	Detail
Eligibility	Leave: employees from day one (since 6 April 2026) who are the father or the partner of the mother or adopter and expect responsibility for the child. SPP and company enhancement: 26 weeks' continuous service by the end of the 15th week before the EWC, employed up to the birth, AWE of at least £129.
Entitlement	Up to 2 weeks, as one 2-week block or two 1-week blocks, ending within 52 weeks of the birth.
Pay	Full basic pay for 2 weeks if SPP-eligible (inclusive of SPP); otherwise unpaid (annual leave may be used).
Notice	Due date at least 15 weeks before the baby is due; 28 days' notice to change start dates.
Steps, approver, deadline	PeopleHub "Paternity leave" form; People Operations confirms within 10 working days.
Escalation and records	Director of People Operations; PeopleHub family-leave record.

Card 5.3 — Adoption leave

Element	Detail
Eligibility	Leave: employees from day one, with correct notice and proof if requested. SAP: 26 weeks' continuous service by the week of matching and AWE of at least £129. Enhanced pay: as maternity, measured at the matching week.
Entitlement and pay	Up to 52 weeks; pay as Card 5.1 (enhanced weeks 1–16, SAP weeks 17–39, unpaid weeks 40–52).
Notice and documents	Notify People Operations as soon as reasonably practicable after being told of the match, with the matching certificate or equivalent evidence.
Approver, deadline, escalation	Not subject to approval; People Operations confirms dates within 28 days; escalation to the Director of People Operations.

Card 5.4 — Shared parental leave

Element	Detail
Eligibility	Continuity test (26 weeks' continuous service by the end of the 15th week before the EWC or matching week, and still employed in the first week of SPL); partner meets the employment and earnings test.
Entitlement and pay	Up to 50 weeks of leave and 37 weeks of ShPP shared; ShPP £194.32 or 90% of AWE if lower. No company enhancement.
Notice	At least 8 weeks' written notice of leave dates, using the PeopleHub SPL forms (based on Acas templates).
Approver and deadline	Continuous blocks cannot be refused. Discontinuous blocks are decided by the Head of Department within 14 days of the notice; if refused, the employee may take the total as a continuous block or withdraw the request.
Escalation	Director of People Operations.

Card 5.5 — Unpaid parental leave

Element	Detail
Eligibility	Employees from day one (since 6 April 2026) named on the birth or adoption certificate or with parental responsibility, for a child under 18.
Entitlement and pay	18 weeks per child; maximum 4 weeks per child per year; whole weeks unless the child is disabled or Northstar agrees otherwise. Unpaid.
Notice	21 days before the start date, stating start and end dates.
Approver and deadline	Line manager responds within 7 days; postponement of up to 6 months only for undue business disruption, confirmed in writing within 7 days with new dates (not available for leave immediately after a birth or adoption).
Escalation and records	Head of Department; PeopleHub records the weeks used per child.

Worked example 5.5 — parental leave balance

An employee has two children and took 3 weeks of parental leave for their elder child in 2027. In 2027 they may take at most 1 more week for the elder child (4-week annual limit per child) and up to 4 weeks for the younger child. The elder child's lifetime balance is 18 − 3 = 15 weeks remaining.

Card 5.6 — Neonatal care leave

Element	Detail
Eligibility	Leave: employees from day one whose baby was admitted to neonatal care within 28 days of birth for at least 7 full consecutive days. Statutory pay: 26 weeks' continuous service and minimum earnings. Company top-up: 26 weeks' continuous service.
Entitlement and pay	One week per full week in neonatal care, up to 12 weeks, taken within 68 weeks of birth. Full basic pay with 26 weeks' service; otherwise statutory pay if eligible, or unpaid.
Notice and approver	Notify the line manager as soon as possible; People Operations confirms. No approval required.

Card 5.7 — Time off for dependants and carer's leave

Element	Detail
Time off for dependants	Reasonable unpaid time for unexpected emergencies involving a dependant (statutory, day one). Company pays up to 2 working days per occurrence, maximum 5 paid days per leave year. Notify the line manager as soon as reasonably practicable by call.
Carer's leave	Up to 1 week in any 12 months (statutory, day one, unpaid) in half days, days or a week, for a dependant with a long-term care need. Notice: at least 3 days for up to 1 day; at least twice the length of leave for more than 1 day. No evidence required. Company pays the first 3 days in any rolling 12 months.
Approver and escalation	Line manager; Head of Department. Carer's leave may be postponed only where operations would be unduly disrupted, with an alternative date within 1 month.

Worked examples 5.7 — dependants and carer's leave

- An employee's childminder cancels unexpectedly on Monday and they take Monday and Tuesday off to arrange care: 2 paid days (time off for dependants). Later in the same leave year they have used 5 paid days in total; a further emergency day is unpaid unless they choose annual leave.
- An employee requests 2 days of carer's leave starting Monday 8 March 2027. Notice must be at least 4 days (twice the leave). A request made on Wednesday 3 March 2027 gives 5 days' notice and is valid. The first 3 carer's leave days in the rolling 12 months are paid, so both days are paid if no carer's leave was taken in the previous 12 months.

6 Other leave procedures

Table 6.1 — Other leave: procedure summary

Leave	Entitlement	Paid?	Notice	Approver	Response
Compassionate (immediate family)	Up to 5 working days per bereavement, within 3 months	Yes	As soon as possible	Line manager	Same day
Parental bereavement	2 weeks, within 56 weeks	Yes, full pay (company)	As soon as possible	Line manager (notification only)	Same day
Pregnancy loss before 24 weeks	Up to 5 working days	Yes	As soon as possible	Line manager	Same day
Funeral of other relative or friend	1 working day	Yes	As soon as possible	Line manager	Same day
Jury service	As required	First 10 working days per leave year	Within 2 working days of summons	Line manager	5 working days
Public duties	Reasonable time	Up to 5 days per leave year	10 working days where possible	Line manager	5 working days
Unpaid personal leave	Up to 10 working days per leave year	No	10 working days	Head of Department	5 working days
Sabbatical	1 to 3 months; 5 years' service; once per 5 years	No	3 months	Director	20 working days
Study and exam leave	Up to 5 days per leave year	Yes	10 working days	Line manager	5 working days
Reservist training	Up to 10 working days per leave year	Yes	On receipt of orders	Line manager	5 working days
Volunteering	Up to 2 days per leave year	Yes	10 working days	Line manager	5 working days
Emergency (non-dependant)	Up to 1 day	Yes, at discretion	As soon as possible	Line manager	Same day

Worked example 6.1 — jury service

An employee is summoned for jury service lasting 13 working days in May 2027 and has had no jury service earlier in 2027. Northstar pays full basic pay for the first 10 working days; the employee must not claim loss of earnings from the court for those days. For the remaining 3 working days Northstar does not pay, and the employee claims loss of earnings from the court.

Worked example 6.2 — sabbatical eligibility

An employee who started on 1 May 2021 applies on 10 April 2026 for a sabbatical starting 1 August 2026. On the start date they would have 5 years and 3 months of service, but on the date of application they have less than 5 years. Eligibility is assessed at the proposed start date, so they are eligible to apply, and the application is made more than 3 months ahead. Approval remains at the Director's discretion.

7 Leave decision table

Table 7.1 — Comparison of leave types

Leave type	Statutory or company	Day-one right?	Paid by Northstar?	Notice	Can it be refused?
Annual leave	Statutory minimum plus company	Yes (accrued)	Yes	2 to 40 working days	Timing can be declined for business reasons
Sickness	Statutory (SSP) plus company sick pay	SSP: yes; company sick pay after probation	Yes, per Table 4.4	By 09:30 on day 1	No
Maternity / adoption leave	Statutory plus company pay	Leave: yes	Enhanced pay if eligible	15th week before EWC / after matching	No
Paternity leave	Statutory plus company pay	Yes (since 6 April 2026)	Full pay if SPP-eligible	15 weeks before due date	No
Shared parental leave	Statutory	No (26-week continuity test)	ShPP only	8 weeks	Discontinuous blocks only
Unpaid parental leave	Statutory	Yes (since 6 April 2026)	No	21 days	Postponed up to 6 months
Neonatal care leave	Statutory plus company top-up	Leave: yes	Full pay with 26 weeks' service	As soon as possible	No
Time off for dependants	Statutory plus company pay	Yes	Up to 2 days per occurrence, 5 per year	As soon as practicable	No, if genuine emergency
Carer's leave	Statutory plus company pay	Yes	First 3 days in 12 months	3 days or twice the length	Postponed only
Compassionate leave	Company	Yes	Yes, up to limits	As soon as possible	No (within limits)
Jury service	Statutory time off; company pay	Yes	First 10 working days	2 working days after summons	Deferral request only
Unpaid personal leave	Discretionary	Yes	No	10 working days	Yes
Sabbatical	Discretionary	No (5 years' service)	No	3 months	Yes

8 Recordkeeping and review

All decisions under this Standard are recorded in PeopleHub with dates, approver and reasons for any refusal. People Operations reviews leave data quarterly for consistency and fairness, including whether refusals disproportionately affect any group. This Standard is reviewed by 1 October 2027.

Table 8.1 — Version history, Leave and Absence Standard NDS-HR-LAS-002

Version	Date	Summary
1.0	June 2026	Internal working draft; not issued.
1.1	August 2026	Consultation draft; not issued.
1.2	Effective 1 October 2026	Approved by the Executive Leadership Team on 9 September 2026. Supersedes Leave Policy NDS-HR-LV-006 v1.0.